

Elicitation for Solution & ERP Sales

Getting deal truth without asking questions — 10 field cases and 30 Bangla statements

Field guide for Account Managers

Part 1 — Why statements beat questions

Questions announce that information is being extracted. The moment a buyer registers that he is being questioned about something sensitive — price, budget, competitors, internal politics — a guard goes up and the answers get shorter and safer.

A statement does not trigger that. It puts a version of reality on the table, and the other person responds to it as a peer rather than as a subject. Three reflexes do the work for you: people correct what is inaccurate about themselves, they place themselves inside a range they are offered, and they defend the difficulty of what they do when you suggest it was easy.

The rule of thumb: the more sensitive the information you need, the fewer questions you should be asking.

Where this comes from: this is an interview technique developed in intelligence work and now taught widely in negotiation and sales training. The version summarised here follows a recent podcast discussion of it — the underlying method is the same one that produces the entire discovery section of a good ERP qualification, without a single question mark.

Part 2 — The five moves

Move	What it does	Example
1. Statement, not question	A question puts the other person on the defensive; a statement invites them to volunteer. The more sensitive the information, the fewer questions you should be asking.	"Most factories your size are still closing costing manually."
2. Correcting the record	People have a strong reflex to fix an inaccurate picture of themselves or their business. Put a slightly-off version of their reality on the table and they will straighten it out for you — with detail you never asked for.	"My assumption was your store issue is already fully in the system."
3. Bracketing	Offer a range instead of asking for a number. They will place themselves inside it, above it, or below it — and any of the three tells you what you needed.	"Projects like this usually run 20 to 35 lakh a year for a factory this size."
4. Disbelief	Once they have started talking, express mild doubt that it was all smooth. The instinct to prove there were real	"With 42 lines and three shifts, there is no way the month-end close is painless."

Move	What it does	Example
	difficulties opens the second and third layer of the problem.	
5. The "so" / "I bet" ladder	Recap what they said back to them starting with "So...", or lead with "I bet...". Both are statements, both invite correction, and both keep the conversation going without a single question mark.	"So the real bottleneck is not production, it is that accounts gets the data late."

Part 3 — The line we do not cross

This technique works because the statement is plausible, not because it is false. Keep it that way:

- **Use "my assumption was" and "usually / normally", not "I heard"**. An assumption you actually hold is honest and provokes exactly the same correction. A fabricated source ("I heard from someone at your buyer...") is a lie, and in a market this small it will find you.
- **Never invent a competitor's number**. "Perpetual quotes usually exclude implementation" is a market observation. "I heard they quoted you 15 lakh" is fabrication.
- **Never elicit something you would not be willing to admit having asked for**. If the buyer would feel tricked on learning what you were doing, you have crossed from professional discovery into manipulation — and a manipulated buyer becomes a hostile customer during implementation.

Elicitation is a listening technique, not a deception technique. Used properly, the buyer ends the meeting feeling that he was understood — not that he was worked.

Part 4 — Ten field cases

Case 1 — Finding the real pain in the first meeting

What you need to find out: How bad is the costing / data problem, really — and does the MD feel it personally?

Do not ask: *"What problems are you facing with your current system?" (You will get a rehearsed, generic answer, or "no problem, everything is fine.")*

Say instead: *"Factories at your volume usually get their actual costing two to three months after shipment. My assumption is yours comes faster than that."*

Technique: Bracketing + correcting the record

What it should surface: The actual lag, who complains about it, and whether the MD is personally chasing numbers. If he corrects you downward, you have found a strength. If he corrects upward, he has just told you his pain in his own words — which is far more usable in your proposal than anything you could have told him.

Next rung: Follow with disbelief: "With that kind of turnover, there is no way that costs you anything material." He will then quantify the loss for you.

Case 2 — Getting to budget without asking for budget

What you need to find out: Is there money, and roughly how much?

Do not ask: *"What is your budget for this project?" (You will hear "give us your best price first.")*

Say instead: *"Composite units your size usually keep somewhere between 20 and 35 lakh a year aside for systems — and implementation normally lands close to the licence figure."*

Technique: Bracketing

What it should surface: Whether a budget line exists at all, whether it is annual or one-time in their head, and whether your number is inside or outside their frame. Silence or a flinch is also data.

Next rung: "So it has not gone into this year's plan yet." — that single recap tells you whether you are selling into this fiscal year or the next one.

Case 3 — Identifying who actually signs

What you need to find out: The real economic buyer, not the person in front of you.

Do not ask: *"Who is the decision maker?" (Everyone claims to be one.)*

Say instead: *"My assumption was that an investment at this level does not need to be put in front of the board separately."*

Technique: Correcting the record

What it should surface: Whether there is a board, a family council, a group CFO, or a director in another country. People correct this immediately because getting it wrong is slightly insulting to them.

Next rung: "So the proposal goes from you straight to the MD, nothing in between."

Case 4 — Finding out about the competing vendor

What you need to find out: Who else is quoting, and on what commercial model.

Do not ask: *"Are you talking to other vendors?" (They will say no, or refuse to name them.)*

Say instead: *"My assumption is that we are the only one you have looked at so far. In this market, two or three vendors usually quote together."*

Technique: Correcting the record + bracketing

What it should surface: Names, count, and often the commercial shape of the competing offer. Then: "Perpetual licence quotes normally keep implementation and support outside the number" — and they will tell you what is and is not in the rival quote.

Next rung: Disbelief on the price: "At that figure there is no way data migration is included." Now you are being handed the competitor's scope gaps.

Case 5 — Uncovering the failed previous system

What you need to find out: What they bought before, what went wrong, and whose reputation is attached to it.

Do not ask: *"Why did your old system fail?" (Someone in the room chose it. You have just made an enemy.)*

Say instead: *"A system that size usually goes live module by module — payroll and store first, then production. My guess is you got through most of the roadmap."*

Technique: Correcting the record, phrased so the correction is not humiliating

What it should surface: How far they actually got, what stalled it, whether it was the vendor, the data, or internal adoption. The person who defends the old system hardest is the person who signed it — that is your consistency risk, identified in one exchange.

Next rung: "So the sticking point was never the software, it was that the floor data never came in clean."

Case 6 — Establishing the real decision timeline

What you need to find out: When a decision will actually be made — not when they say they want it.

Do not ask: *"When are you planning to decide?" ("Soon, inshallah.")*

Say instead: *"Most of these decisions take three to six months from first demo to signature. My sense is you want to be live before peak season."*

Technique: Bracketing + presumptive statement

What it should surface: The real constraint driving the date — a buyer audit, a new line, a compliance deadline, a fiscal year. If nothing corrects your range, there is no deadline, which means there is no deal yet.

Next rung: "So if it does not happen this quarter, it moves to next fiscal year."

Case 7 — Finding the internal blocker

What you need to find out: Who loses if you win.

Do not ask: *"Is anyone opposed to this project?" (Nobody will name a colleague to a vendor.)*

Say instead: *"I imagine your IT in-charge is quite keen on getting off the old platform."*

Technique: Presumptive statement inviting correction

What it should surface: A pause, a diplomatic answer, or a laugh — all three are answers. This is the single most valuable thing elicitation buys you in ERP selling, because internal resistance almost never appears in a CRM as a risk.

Next rung: "And usually it is production that pushes back hardest on go-live timing." Now you know which department will kill your date.

Case 8 — Testing whether there is real urgency

What you need to find out: Is there a compelling event, or is this a nice-to-have?

Do not ask: *"How urgent is this for you?"*

Say instead: *"My assumption is that no buyer has put traceability pressure on you yet."*

Technique: Correcting the record

What it should surface: Compliance, audit, or buyer-driven pressure is the strongest urgency source in RMG. If they correct you — "actually our European buyer has asked for it" — you have found the compelling event that justifies the whole investment, and you can build the business case around their buyer instead of around your features.

Next rung: Disbelief: "Surely they have not put a date on it." They will give you the date.

Case 9 — Getting technical constraints out of IT without an interrogation

What you need to find out: Data quality, existing systems, integration reality.

Do not ask: *A twenty-item technical questionnaire emailed to the IT in-charge.*

Say instead: *"Master data in factories like this is usually reasonably clean on the item side — it is the BOM and the size-colour breakdown that tends to be scattered."*

Technique: Correcting the record among peers

What it should surface: Technical people correct technical inaccuracies faster than anyone. You will learn the true state of their data in two minutes, and you will have positioned yourself as someone who has seen this before rather than someone taking notes.

Next rung: "So the migration effort is really about BOM standardisation, not volume."

Case 10 — Diagnosing silence after the proposal

What you need to find out: Where the proposal is actually stuck.

Do not ask: *"Just following up — any update?"*

Say instead: *"After this much detail I assume there are no open questions left, and it is only the commercial part remaining."*

Technique: Presumptive close by statement

What it should surface: Either confirmation (move to negotiation) or a correction that names the real objection — price, risk, timing, or an internal person who has not been convinced. Either way the silence ends.

Next rung: If they correct you on price, bracket it: "Usually the gap in these cases is 15 to 20 percent." They will tell you the real gap.

Part 5 — Thirty elicitation statements in Bangla

Use these as written, or adapt the wording to the room. The English column is what the statement is designed to extract — never read it out.

If the Bangla text shows as boxes on your machine, install or select a Bangla font such as Nirmala UI, SolaimanLipi or Kalpurush.

A. Current state and pain

#	বাংলা এলিসিটেশন স্টেটমেন্ট	What it surfaces
1	আপনাদের সাইজের ফ্যাক্টুরিতে সাধারণত শিপমেন্টের দুই-তিন মাস পর অ্যাকচুয়াল কস্টিং বের হয় — আপনাদেরটা মনে হয় এর চেয়ে দ্রুত হয়ে যায়।	Real costing lag. Bracketing + correction.
2	আমার ধারণা ছিল, স্টোর থেকে প্রোডাকশনে ম্যাটেরিয়াল ইস্যুর হিসাবটা আপনাদের এখন সিস্টেমেই চলে যায়।	Whether store consumption is on paper or in a system.
3	এত বড় অপারেশনে মাস শেষে ডাটা মেলাতে গিয়ে নিশ্চয়ই বেশ ঝামেলা পোহাতে হয়।	Month-end close pain, in their words.
4	তাহলে প্রোডাকশন, মার্চেন্ডাইজিং আর অ্যাকাউন্টস — তিন জায়গায় তিন রকম সংখ্যা থাকে।	Confirms data fragmentation. Recap statement.
5	আপনাদের মতো কমপ্লায়েন্স-স্ট্রং ফ্যাক্টুরিতে বায়ার অডিটের সময় ডাটা বের করা নিশ্চয়ই আর কোনো সমস্যা না।	Audit readiness and reporting pain.
6	আমার ধারণা ছিল ওয়েস্টেজ পার্সেন্টেজটা আপনারা লাইন-ওয়াইজ ট্র্যাক করেন।	Granularity of existing tracking.

B. Budget and commercials

#	বাংলা এলিসিটেশন স্টেটমেন্ট	What it surfaces
7	আপনাদের মতো ভলিউমের ফ্যাক্টরিগুলো সাধারণত সিস্টেমের পেছনে বছরে ২০ থেকে ৩৫ লাখের মতো রাখে।	Budget range. Pure bracketing.
8	সাধারণত এই ধরনের প্রজেক্টে ইমপ্লিমেন্টেশন খরচটা লাইসেন্স খরচের কাছাকাছিই দাঁড়ায়।	Whether they have costed implementation at all.

#	বাংলা এলিসিটেশন স্টেটমেন্ট	What it surfaces
9	তাহলে বাজেটটা এখনো এই অর্থবছরের প্ল্যানে ঢোকানো হয়নি।	Whether the money exists this fiscal year.
10	আমার ধারণা, এই খরচটা ক্যাপেক্স হিসেবেই ধরা হবে, অপেক্স হিসেবে নয়।	How finance will treat a subscription — a real objection source.
11	এই সাইজের ইনভেস্টমেন্টে নিশ্চয়ই এমডি স্যারের বাইরে আর কারো অনুমোদন লাগে না।	Approval threshold and hidden signatories.

C. Decision process and authority

#	বাংলা এলিসিটেশন স্টেটমেন্ট	What it surfaces
12	তাহলে সিদ্ধান্তটা মূলত আপনি আর ফাইন্যান্স মিলেই নেবেন।	The real decision unit.
13	আমার ধারণা ছিল, এই ধরনের কেনাকাটায় আলাদা করে বোর্ডে উপস্থাপন করতে হয় না।	Existence of a board or group-level step.
14	সাধারণত দেখি, প্রথম ডেমোর পর আরও দুই-তিনটা মিটিং লাগে ফাইনাল হতে।	Number of remaining steps in their process.
15	নিশ্চয়ই আইটি টিম টেকনিক্যাল ইভালুয়েশনটা আলাদা করে করবে।	Whether a technical gate exists that you have not planned for.
16	তাহলে প্রপোজালটা আপনার কাছ থেকে সরাসরি এমডি স্যারের কাছে যাবে, মাঝখানে আর কোনো ধাপ নেই।	Hidden approval layers.

D. Competition and alternatives

#	বাংলা এলিসিটেশন স্টেটমেন্ট	What it surfaces
17	আমার ধারণা, এখন পর্যন্ত আপনারা শুধু আমাদেরটাই দেখেছেন।	Whether competitors are in play, and who.
18	এই মার্কেটে সাধারণত দুই-তিনটা ভেন্ডর একসাথে কোট করে।	Number of vendors, without asking for names.
19	পার্শ্বচ্যুত লাইসেন্সের কোটগুলোতে সাধারণত ইমপ্লিমেন্টেশন আর সাপোর্ট আলাদা ধরা থাকে।	The scope gaps in the competing quote.

#	বাংলা এলিসিটেশন স্টেটমেন্ট	What it surfaces
20	তাহলে আগের ভেস্তরের সাথে এখনো এএমসি চালু আছে।	Contractual lock-in and switching cost.

E. Timeline and urgency

#	বাংলা এলিসিটেশন স্টেটমেন্ট	What it surfaces
21	আমার ধারণা ছিল, পিক সিজনের আগেই আপনারা লাইভে যেতে চান।	The real target date and its driver.
22	সাধারণত ডিসেম্বর-জানুয়ারির মধ্যেই পরের বছরের সিস্টেম প্ল্যান ফাইনাল হয়ে যায়।	Their planning cycle — when money gets allocated.
23	তাহলে এই কোয়ার্টারে সিদ্ধান্ত না হলে বিষয়টা পরের অর্থবছরে চলে যাবে।	Whether delay has a real cost to them.
24	নিশ্চয়ই বায়ারের দিক থেকে ট্রেসেবিলিটি নিয়ে এখনো কোনো চাপ আসেনি।	The compelling event. The strongest one in RMG.

F. Internal politics and blockers

#	বাংলা এলিসিটেশন স্টেটমেন্ট	What it surfaces
25	আমার ধারণা, আইটি ইনচার্জ সাহেব নতুন সিস্টেম নিয়ে বেশ আগ্রহী।	Whether IT is an ally or a quiet opponent.
26	সাধারণত প্রোডাকশনের দিক থেকেই সবচেয়ে বেশি আপত্তি আসে।	Which department will resist go-live.
27	তাহলে আগের সিস্টেমটা যিনি সুপারিশ করেছিলেন, তিনি এখনো টিমেই আছেন।	Who owns the previous decision — your consistency risk.

G. Positioning and closing

#	বাংলা এলিসিটেশন স্টেটমেন্ট	What it surfaces
28	তাহলে আপনার কাছে সবচেয়ে জরুরি হলো রিয়েল-টাইম কস্টিং, বাকিগুলো পরে হলেও চলবে।	Priority order — lets you phase the proposal.

#	বাংলা এলিসিটেশন স্টেটমেন্ট	What it surfaces
29	আমার ধারণা, ৯০ দিনের মধ্যে প্রথম রেজাল্ট দেখাতে পারলে বাকি টিমকে রাজি করানো সহজ হয়ে যাবে।	Whether a quick-win phase would unlock internal support.
30	এত আলোচনার পর নিশ্চয়ই আর বড় কোনো প্রশ্ন বাকি নেই — শুধু কমাশিয়াল অংশটা বাকি।	The real remaining objection, or a move to negotiation.

Part 6 — How to drill this

1. Pick one live account. Before the next meeting, write down the three things you do not know: budget, decision process, competition. Write one statement for each. Do not go in without them.
2. In the meeting, allow yourself a maximum of three questions. Everything else must be a statement.
3. Debrief the same day: which statement produced a correction? Which produced nothing? A statement that produces nothing was either too vague or too accurate.
4. Weekly, in the sales meeting: each AM reads out one statement he used and what it surfaced. Build the team's own library from what actually worked in Bangladeshi factories.

The measure of success: at the end of a first meeting you can fill in budget range, decision process, timeline driver, competing options and internal blocker — and the buyer feels he had a good conversation, not an interview.